MISSIONQUAL

THE TRANSITION GUIDE

From Oil & Gas to Data Center Construction

A guide for API inspectors, CWIs, QA/QC and trades: the roles to target, the skills that transfer, and where the jobs are.



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Who this is for. API 510, 570 and 653 inspectors, CWIs, NDT techs and QA/QC people. Pipefitters, welders, electricians and instrument fitters. Turnover, completions and document control. Anyone in oil and gas, from refinery and turnaround work to LNG, petrochemical and offshore, who wants to know what a data center job really is before they apply.

Who wrote it. Two people who made this move and are on data center site now.

START HERE

The short version

If you only read one page, read this one.

Five things to know

1. **The work is real and it lasts.** Data center construction spending is up more than 70% in a year. A turnaround runs ten weeks; one campus can run for ten years.
2. **It is construction, not IT.** The work centers on large-scale mechanical and electrical infrastructure — piping, welds, cooling systems, switchgear, testing, commissioning, and turnover — all built to keep servers and other critical computing equipment powered, cooled, and available
3. **Most of what you do already transfers.** If you already inspect welds, review drawings and specifications, witness tests, manage punch lists or NCRs, verify documentation, and support turnover, much of that experience carries into data center construction. The systems, terminology, and mission-critical expectations are what change. **Section 3 shows you how your industrial experience translates**.
4. **Compare the whole pay package.** Data center roles can include overtime, per diem, bonuses, travel allowances, and rotation schedules. A lower base rate can still produce a better total package — or the opposite. **Section 7 shows posted ranges and what to ask before accepting an offer.**
5. Learn the commissioning levels before you interview: Many data center teams use L1 through L5 to describe the progression from equipment verification through startup, functional testing, integrated systems testing, and final readiness. Interviewers may expect you to understand how those levels fit together. **Section 6 breaks them down.**

Three things to do this week

- [ ] Change your LinkedIn headline using the titles in section 4.
- [ ] Rewrite five résumé lines with the before-and-after table in section 8.
- [ ] Prepare one question to ask in the MissionQual community.

SECTION 1

Why now

More money is going into data center construction than into almost any other kind of building in the country, the companies paying for it say they will spend more next year, and there are not enough people to build it.

The money. US data center construction spending was up more than 73% in August 2026 compared with a year earlier, at an annual pace of about $85 billion (Construction Dive). Amazon plans about $220 billion of capital spending this year, Alphabet $195–205 billion, Microsoft roughly $175 billion, Meta $130–145 billion (Fortune, W.Media, Microsoft call, Meta). Much of that is chips and servers, but every one of them needs a building, power and cooling first.

The people. The construction industry needs about 349,000 more workers in 2026 than it has, and 456,000 in 2027 (ABC). Data center job postings more than doubled in two years while total US postings fell about 12% (Indeed Hiring Lab). Louisiana's industrial press reports data centers are "already stealing skilled laborers" from the LNG and petrochemical labor pool (10/12 Industry Report), and union halls as far away as North Dakota are dispatching pipefitters to data center calls.

How long it lasts.

A turnaround lasts weeks; one campus can keep a crew working for a decade



Length of the work, start to finish, on one time scale. Dates from DCD, Epoch AI, WWNO and Meta; turnaround length typical.

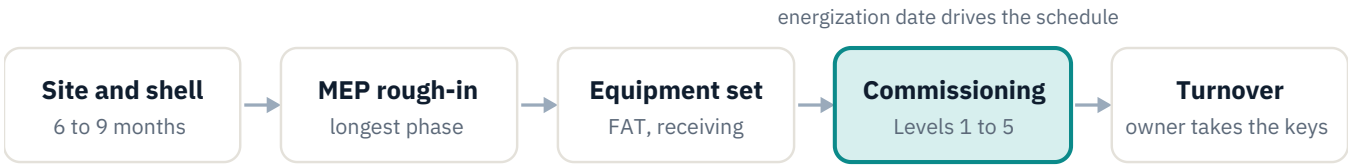
The honest caveat. Power is the constraint. Projects get delayed and re-sequenced, and in August 2026 Texas paused new grid connections pending an audit (Texas Standard). Even so, a record 7,400 MW was under construction in the eight largest US markets at mid-2026 (CBRE). Treat it like any boom you have worked through: real and big, but no reason to burn bridges in oil and gas.

SECTION 2

How a data center gets built

A data center build has a lot in common with industrial construction: structural steel, piping, equipment, electrical work and turnover. The key difference is the critical power and cooling systems, and the inspections and testing needed to prove they work together before the owner takes over. That is where an experienced QA/QC inspector can contribute.

Your experience lands in every phase of a data center build

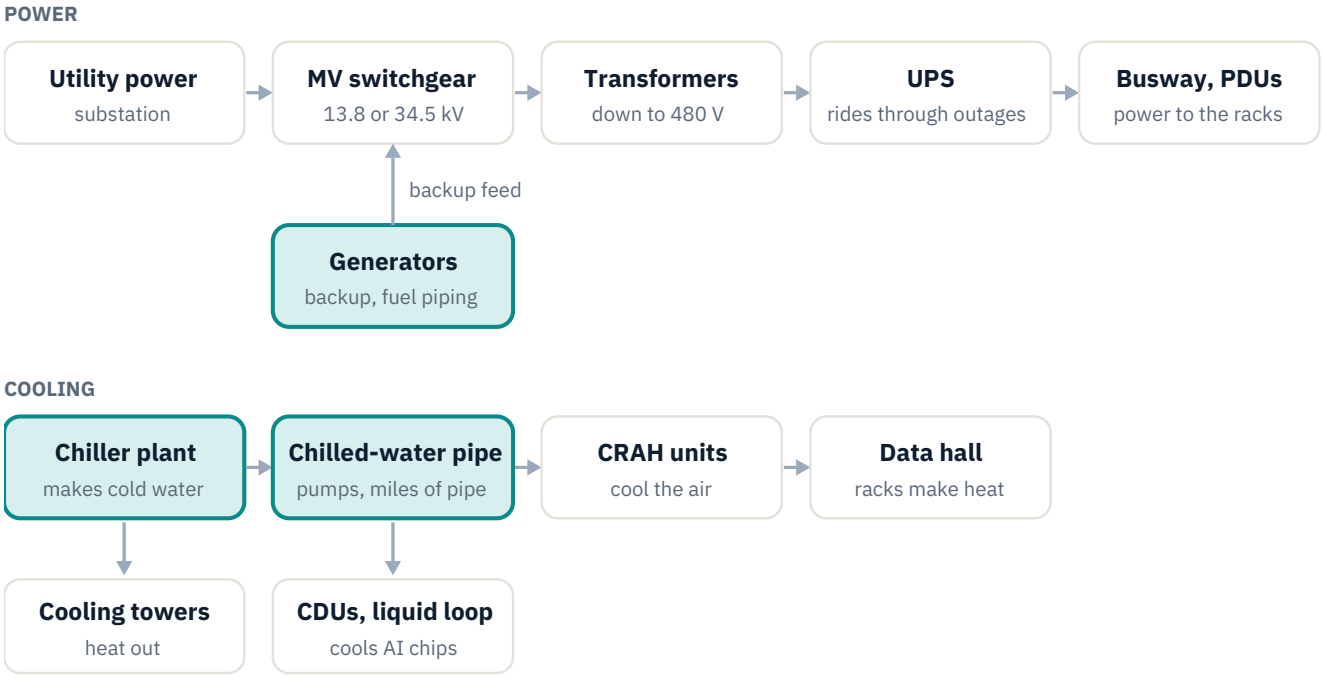


WHERE YOUR EXPERIENCE LANDS

QC inspector, welding inspector piping QC, electrical QC field engineer, pipefitter, electrician welder, instrument fitter	commissioning agent, Cx engineer MEP QA/QC manager startup technician I&E technician	turnover lead document control owner QA manager

The first two phases look like an industrial job: earthwork, steel, duct banks, pipe spools, welds, hydrotests, hangers, torque, megger. The last three are where the data center vocabulary takes over, and where the pay climbs.

Two plants in one building: where the power and the cooling go



Teal boxes: the scopes closest to oil and gas work.

The players

WHO	WHAT THEY DO	EXAMPLES
Owner	Pays for it, sets the quality program, has its own quality managers on site	Meta, Microsoft, Google, AWS, Oracle; developers such as Vantage, QTS, Aligned
Owner's rep	Watches the job for the owner; reviews turnover packages, MOPs, schedules	Decima International, KALCON, Cumming, DLB
General contractor	Runs the site; owns the Quality Management Plan, ITPs and schedule	Turner, DPR, Mortenson, Holder, HITT, Clayco
MEP subcontractors	Install switchgear, generators, UPS, chillers, piping, controls; most of the labor	Rosendin, Bergelectric, MMR Group, Southland
Commissioning authority (CxA)	Writes and runs the tests, keeps the issues log, signs for the owner	AEI, CAI, Salas O'Brien, Newcomb & Boyd
Staffing firms	Place contract QA/QC and Cx staff with per diem; the fastest way in	Insight Global, Actalent, Kelly, NES Fircroft, TRS

You know this cast already: owner, PMC, EPC, subs, third-party inspection. The one role with no clean match is the CxA. Think of it as a third-party inspection firm that only does startup and performance testing, with the owner's signature behind it.

Not an IT job. Once the building is live, a much smaller crew runs it. The servers and networking are a separate world with separate hiring. If a posting asks about Linux or Cisco, it is the other world, and you can close the tab.

SECTION 3

The Translation Sheet

You already do most of this work. The words are different, and the words are what a recruiter's software and a hiring manager's eyes are scanning for. Put the middle column on your résumé. Use the right-hand column so you never claim more than you have.

OIL AND GAS	DATA CENTER BUILD	WHAT IS ACTUALLY DIFFERENT
ITP, hold and witness points	ITP, Quality Management Plan, hold points, quality gates	Same idea. The owner often issues its own quality procedures the GC's plan must follow.
NCR	NCR, plus the CxA's issues log	Commissioning failures live in a separate issues log, not only in the GC's NCR system.
FAT (factory acceptance test), SAT (site acceptance test)	L1 factory acceptance testing; L2 site receiving and acceptance checks	FAT and SAT are familiar on oil and gas equipment packages. On many data center projects, L2 covers arrival condition, tags, paperwork and installation readiness—not the full functional SAT you may know.
Pre-commissioning, ITRs, check sheets	Level 3: pre-functional checklists (PFCs) and startup	Filled in on a tablet or phone in CxAlloy, Procore or ACC Build instead of paper.
Mechanical completion	Level 3 complete	No formal MC certificate. Readiness is tracked by system in a commissioning database.
RFSU, ready for startup	Ready for Level 4; energization	Energization, the day utility power comes on, is the most important date on the job.
Commissioning and performance test	Level 4 functional test, Level 5 integrated systems test (IST)	IST runs the whole building as one machine, with load banks standing in for servers.
Punch list A/B/C	Punch list	Minor finish work only. Anything that affects performance goes in the issues log and gets retested.
Turnover package	Turnover documentation package	As-builts, O&M manuals, test reports, closed issues log. Reviewed by the owner's rep before acceptance.
Hydrotest, pressure test	Hydrostatic test, then flush, clean and treat	Chilled-water piping is mostly ASME B31.9, not B31.3. Lower pressures. The flush matters as much as the test.

OIL AND GAS	DATA CENTER BUILD	WHAT IS ACTUALLY DIFFERENT
Weld inspection, WPS, PQR	Weld inspection, WPS, PQR, welder quals	Structural steel to AWS D1.1. Less radiography, more volume. CWI is named in postings; API certs usually are not.
Megger, loop check, point-to-point	Megger, point-to-point, torque verification	Same tests, thousands more of them. NETA standards govern switchgear and transformer acceptance testing.
Process unit, train	Data hall, building, phase	Each hall is commissioned and turned over on its own.
Permit to work, JSA	JSA, MOP (method of procedure)	Once part of a building is live, every task near it needs a written, step-by-step MOP.
LOTO under NFPA 70E	LOTO under NFPA 70E	The same rules you work under now, enforced by the GC's safety team.
Owner, PMC, EPC, subs, third-party inspection	Owner, owner's rep, GC, MEP subs, commissioning authority (CxA)	The CxA is the one role you do not have: the owner's independent test authority.
API 510, 570, 653	No direct equivalent	None of the postings we read asked for them. They still prove you can read a code, hold a line and sign your name to it. Say that in the interview.

Two habits to break early: stop saying "mechanical completion" and "RFSU" on site, and do not treat a performance problem as a punch item. Use the translation sheet in this guide as a starting point.

SECTION 4

Roles to target

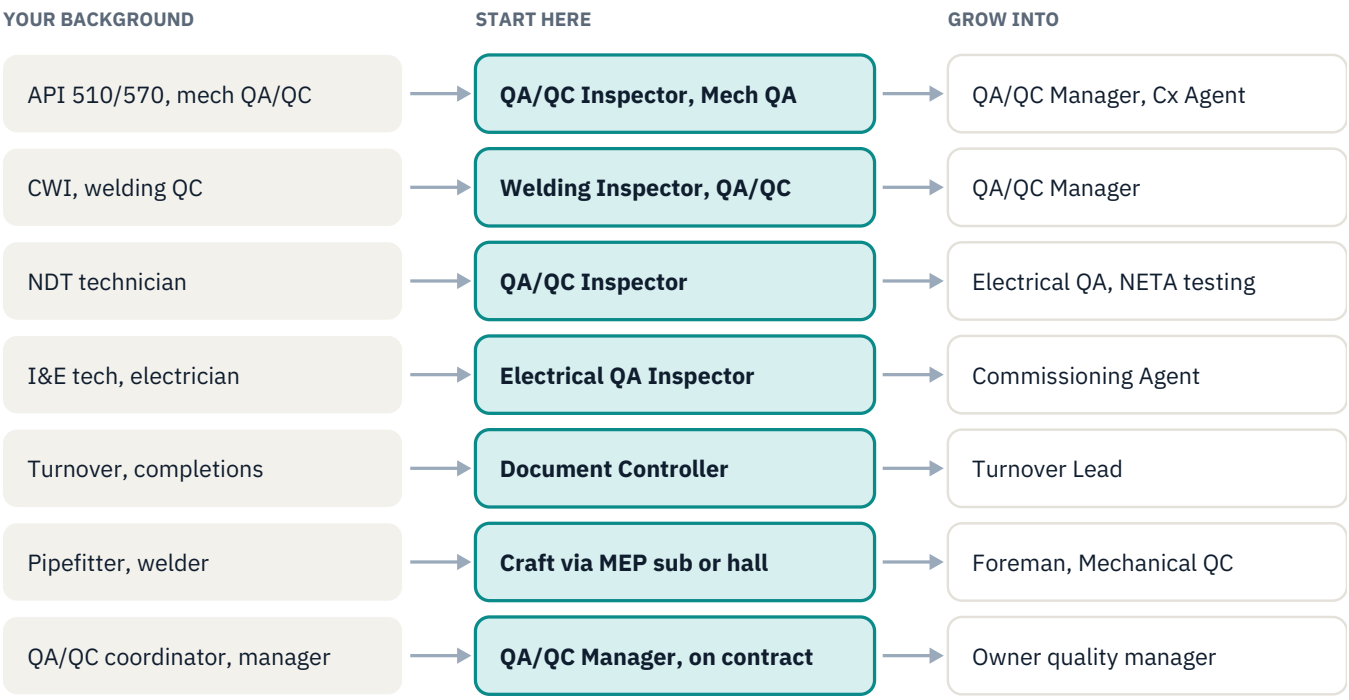
Search these titles word for word. They come from postings live in 2026. In the postings we reviewed, employers generally emphasized construction QA/QC experience, safety and tools such as ACC, Procore, Bluebeam and CxAlloy more than API 510, 570 or 653. Specialist welding roles may ask for CWI or applicable code experience. Read each posting for the actual requirements; your industrial background is the opening.

TITLE AS POSTED	LEVEL	WHO POSTS IT	POSTED PAY
QA/QC Inspector	Inspector	Staffing firms for GCs and owner's reps	$56–70/hr (Insight Global, VA)
MEP QA/QC Inspector (Data Center)	Inspector	Staffing firms	$57–71/hr (Insight Global, VA)
Electrical QA Inspector, Mechanical QA Inspector	Inspector	Owner's rep firms	Salaried (Decima)

TITLE AS POSTED	LEVEL	WHO POSTS IT	POSTED PAY
Data Center QA/QC Specialist, Site Inspector	Inspector	Staffing firms for owners	$130,000–160,000, lodging paid (Kelly Telecom, TX)
Certified Welding Inspector	Inspector	Steel and MEP subs	A way in, not where the money is (Insight Global, TN)
QA/QC Manager, Data Center	Manager	GCs, owner's reps, staffing firms	$80–120/hr contract (Actalent, OH)
Quality Manager (Mission Critical)	Manager	GCs; accepts industrial experience	Not listed (Barton Malow)
Construction Quality Manager	Owner staff	Microsoft and other owners	$125,000–$206,400
Commissioning Agent, Data Center	Commissioning	CxA firms	$80,000–135,000 (Insight Global, TX)
Commissioning Specialist, Data Centers	Commissioning	Staffing firms	$115,000–150,000 (Michael Page)
Document Controller	Turnover	Owner's reps; industrial accepted	Salaried (Decima)

Trades are hired by the MEP subs, often through union halls: Journeyman Electrician, Pipefitter, Pipe Welder, Instrument Fitter, Mechanical Superintendent (Chilled Water Systems). Look for the words "industrial" and "or equivalent experience" in any posting. Those are your openings.

Every oil and gas background has a first data center job and a next step



Use the titles above when searching for openings.

SECTION 5

What transfers

More transfers than most people expect. A data center build is an industrial construction project with a stricter owner and a cleaner floor. Here are the six things you bring on day one, each with the site story to have ready.

WHAT YOU BRING	WHY IT COUNTS ON A DATA CENTER	HAVE THIS STORY READY
Inspection discipline. Reading drawings, specs and codes, walking the work against them, refusing to sign until it matches.	Microsoft's own quality manager posting describes the job as defining "hold points, quality gates, and documentation requirements" and initiating NCRs.	The time you held a hold point under schedule pressure, and what it saved.
ITPs, hold and witness points. Building them, running them, chasing signatures.	Every GC runs a Quality Management Plan with exactly this inside it.	How many ITP points you ran on your last unit and how you kept subs on notification.

WHAT YOU BRING	WHY IT COUNTS ON A DATA CENTER	HAVE THIS STORY READY
Welding and piping. WPS, PQR, welder quals, fit-up, visual, NDT requests, test packages.	Miles of chilled-water pipe, generator fuel lines and structural steel. Less radiography, more volume.	A weld repair rate you drove down, and how.
Electrical and instrument checks. Loop checks, megger, point-to-point, torque.	The core of electrical QC on a data center, times thousands of terminations per building.	How you tracked thousands of checks without losing one.
Turnover and documentation. Packages, as-builts, redlines, vendor data, punch.	The turnover package is what lets the owner take the keys. People who build one that passes first time are valuable.	A turnover you closed clean, and what the owner's rep said.
Working to one hard date, safely. Turnaround startup, permit to work, LOTO, JSA.	A data center has an energization date and a server move-in date nobody moves, and a safety program built on the same NFPA 70E.	The worst schedule you have worked where quality and safety still held.

Recruiters say the same. Airswift tells its clients to source "mission-critical skills from adjacent sectors like oil and gas, aerospace, or the military" (Airswift), and Gray Construction's data center lead says oil and gas contractors have already moved into the work (Bisnow).

One warning. Transferable does not mean automatic. You will be the person on site who knows piping and has never seen a 2 MW UPS lineup or a paralleling switchgear bus. Say so. Hiring managers trust the inspector who says "I know what I don't know yet."

SECTION 6

What changes

Four things are new. None of them needs a degree, and the order below is the order an interviewer will test them.

1. The commissioning levels, L1 to L5. Learn this cold. It is pre-commissioning, commissioning and performance testing split into numbered, witnessed, signed stages.

Each level adds a harder test, ending with the whole building failed on purpose

	DATA CENTER LEVEL	WHO RUNS IT	YOUR OIL AND GAS WORD
L1	**Factory witness test** Tested at the maker before it ships	Vendor runs, CxA witnesses	FAT
L2	**Site acceptance** Receiving, torque, labels, firmware	Trade QC, GC QA/QC, CxA	Receiving inspection, SAT
L3	**Pre-functional and startup** Point-to-point, megger, first power-up	Installer and vendor tech	Pre-commissioning, MC
L4	**Functional performance test** Each system run through its sequence on load banks	MEP subs, GC Cx lead, CxA	Commissioning
L5	**Integrated systems test (IST)** Utility pulled, UPS rides through, generators pick up	Owner, CxA, GC, trade leads	Full-plant test (closest)

Sources: Horizon IQ, Archdesk and CxPlanner.

L4 is where most problems show up; Horizon IQ calls it "the last stage where major issues are typically found" (Horizon IQ). Names shift slightly from owner to owner, and some add a Level 0 or a Level 6, so ask which scheme the project uses (Archdesk, cxplanner).

Site inspection gates you will hear about. SIT (site arrival inspection) checks equipment at delivery for damage, identification and documents. First-of-Kind (FOK) or benchmark inspections approve the first installation as the standard for repeated work. PEI (pre-energization inspection) checks that electrical equipment and required safety and test records are ready before first power. These are project inspection gates, not extra commissioning levels; names and sign-offs vary by owner.

2. The equipment. You do not need to design it. You need to know what each box in the power and cooling diagram in section 2 does, how it fails, and what a good installation looks like. Start with these eight: medium-voltage switchgear, transformers, generators and paralleling gear, UPS, busway and PDUs, chillers, CRAH units, and liquid-cooling CDUs. The fastest way to learn them is the sequence of operations for one building. Ask for it on your first day.

3. The codes you have not used.

CODE	WHAT CHANGES FOR YOU
ASME B31.9, Building Services Piping	Replaces B31.3 for most chilled-water and condenser-water pipe. Simpler rules, its own thickness tables, rarely any radiography. It stops at NPS 30 for carbon steel, so the biggest headers and fuel oil go to B31.1 or B31.3. Check the spec (ASME).

CODE	WHAT CHANGES FOR YOU
AWS D1.1, Structural Welding	The code for the building frame and equipment platforms, and the CWI Part C book for data center work.
NFPA 70 and 70E, NFPA 110	The NEC for every electrical check, 70E for working near energized gear, 110 for generator and transfer testing.
ANSI/NETA ATS	The acceptance testing standard for switchgear, transformers and cable. The test reports you will be reading and filing.

One more change: cleanliness. On a process unit, flushing is usually a specialist's separate scope. In a data center the chilled-water flush sits on the critical path and QC owns the sign-off: alkaline clean at 3 to 5 feet per second for 24 to 72 hours, flush until strainers come up clean, then inhibitor (example spec). Liquid-cooling loops for AI racks are closer to a lube-oil flush: 5-micron filtration, turbidity under 5 NTU (OCP).

4. The software. Postings name jobsite platforms as well as certifications. Know what each tool does: Procore tracks field quality records; Autodesk Construction Cloud (ACC Build) handles forms, inspections, issues and documents; Bluebeam is used for drawing and PDF markups; and CxAlloy manages commissioning checklists, tests and issues. Start with the free learning resources where available; access to the full software may require an account or license.

Certifications can wait. Get OSHA 30 now: online, about $100 to $190, a week of evenings because OSHA caps online training at 7.5 hours a day (OSHA). Pick a commissioning, NETA, ICC or ASQ credential after your first project, when you know which way you want to grow.

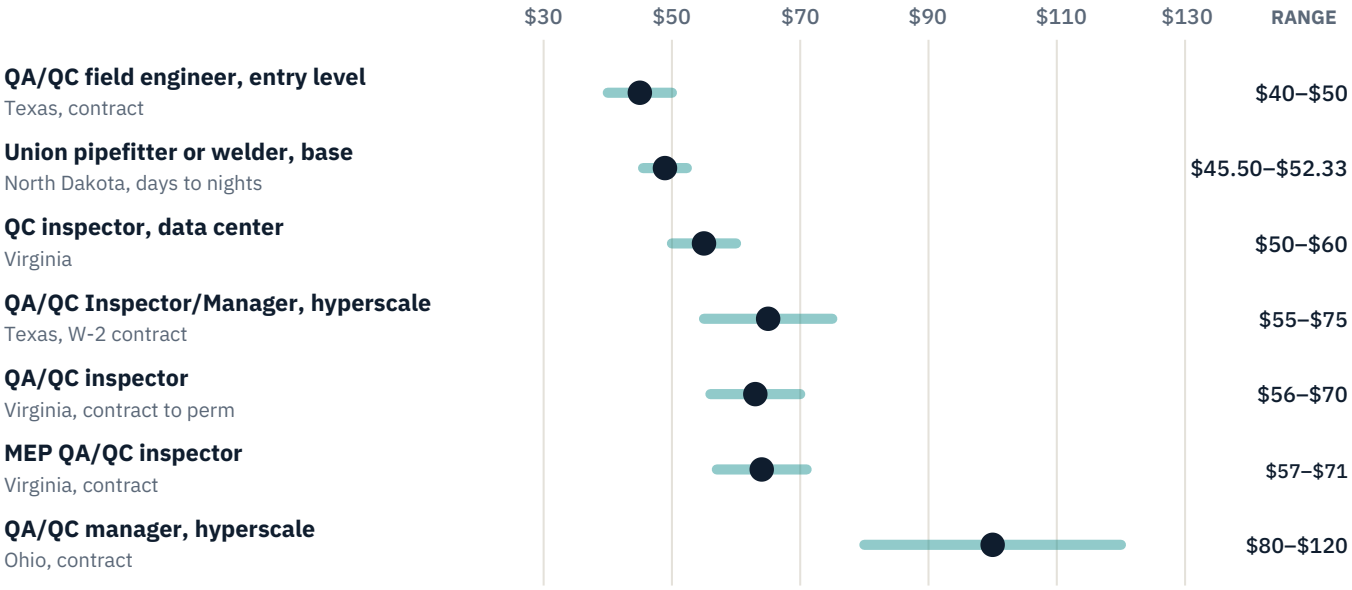
> **Stuck on one of these?** Ask the people who already closed the gap. In the MISSIONQUAL community, oil and gas inspectors and trades now on data center sites answer questions from those still on the way over: which cert first, what a CxA checks at L3, how a staffing offer compares.

SECTION 7

Pay

The pay you see on job boards is usually a starting point, not the final offer. Posted ranges vary by employer, project and experience. If you hold an API or CWI certification and have years of field experience, use that background to negotiate toward the upper end of a published range. Compare overtime and per diem separately—they can make a big difference to the total package.

What data center QA/QC roles actually post



Posted hourly ranges, 2026; dot is the middle of each range. Postings from Insight Global, Contract Safety Professionals, Actalent and the UA, May to October 2026; Rigzone for turnaround.

The chart compares posted hourly ranges, not total compensation. A multi-year campus may offer steadier work than a short turnaround, but the assignment length, schedule and per diem depend on the actual contract. The Advocate). Salaried roles pay in a different register: QA/QC managers up to $200,000, owner quality managers up to $209,000 at Meta, commissioning agents up to $150,000 (section 4).

How to ask

- If you hold API or CWI and have run ITPs on an industrial job, start your ask at the top of these ranges, not the bottom.
- Get each piece in writing separately: hourly rate, overtime terms, per diem, hours per week, rotation, mobilization and travel pay.
- Ask the staffing firm what the last person in the seat was paid. The first offer is rarely the best one.
- Ask how per diem is handled past twelve months. If an assignment is expected to last more than a year, the IRS treats it as indefinite and per diem becomes taxable (AGC guide). Multi-year campuses run into this.
- Contract through a staffing firm is the fastest way in. After one campus you are a "data center person," and direct-hire GC and owner roles open up.

Hours, travel, screening. Expect 50-hour weeks as the baseline and six tens in commissioning. The work is where the power is, often a small town, so sort housing as soon as you accept. Every hyperscale

site we know of runs a background check, a drug test and a badge system; plan on a few days between offer and first day.

SECTION 8

Your résumé, rewritten

Your résumé is read twice: once by software matching words, once by a manager with thirty seconds. Both are looking for the middle column of the Translation Sheet. Give them those words, with specific work you can support.

Five rules

1. Use the exact words from the posting, once each.
2. Plain layout: no tables, columns or photos. Recruiters in this field recommend a simple font such as Arial 10 (Pkaza).
3. Start each bullet with an action verb. Add a real scope, result or number when you can verify it.
4. Dates on every job. Leaving them off is a red flag.
5. Attach a one-page project list: site, owner, contractor, your role, systems, dates.

Before and after

WHAT YOU HAVE NOW	REWRITE IT AS
API 510/570 inspector on refinery turnarounds	QA/QC inspector on refinery and LNG projects; inspected pressure equipment, piping and welds against API/ASME codes and owner specifications.
Performed inspections per ITP	Executed ITP hold and witness points for piping and mechanical scopes; documented findings, coordinated with construction and resolved outstanding items before release.
Responsible for weld inspection	Inspected weld fit-up, root and final visual against approved procedures; coordinated NDT requests and tracked weld repairs through acceptance.
Witnessed hydrotests	Reviewed and witnessed hydrostatic tests, including test limits, calibrated gauges, hold periods and reinstatement; verified complete test packages for turnover.
Wrote NCRs	Raised and tracked NCRs; documented nonconformances, coordinated corrective actions and verified repairs or reinspection before closeout.

WHAT YOU HAVE NOW	REWRITE IT AS
Did turnover packages	Assembled turnover packages with inspection reports, test records, redlines and vendor documents; worked with contractors to close missing items before submission.
Handled loop checks	Performed instrument loop and point-to-point checks; documented test results, tracked open items and supported pre-commissioning readiness.
Safety	Worked under permit-to-work, LOTO, confined-space and hot-work requirements; verified required safety controls before inspection activities.

Use these as examples of how to describe work you actually did. Add quantities and outcomes only when you can verify them, and do not claim data center experience you do not have.

The summary, four lines

> QA/QC inspector with 12 years on industrial construction and turnaround projects for refinery and LNG owners. Pressure equipment, piping, structural steel and electrical completions to ASME, API, AWS and owner specifications. Experienced in ITPs, hold points, NCR management, hydrostatic testing and turnover documentation on multi-contractor sites with fixed startup dates. OSHA 30. Seeking QA/QC or commissioning role on mission-critical construction.

Certs line. List API 510, 570, CWI, NDT levels and OSHA 30 in full with expiry dates, CWI first if you have it. Nobody will search for the API certs, but every manager who reads them knows what they took to earn.

LinkedIn headline. Change it today. Not "API 510 Inspector at XYZ Refinery." Try: QA/QC Inspector | Industrial Construction & Turnarounds | ITPs, Weld & Piping Inspection, Turnover | Open to Mission-Critical / Data Center Projects. Recruiters search by those words.

SECTION 9

The interview

Mission-critical interviews are half technical and half "show me how you think." Nobody expects you to know a UPS on day one. They do expect you to explain your own process clearly and to be honest about what you have not touched. One recruiter who screens for these roles: "If they can't explain their process clearly, that's a red flag" (iRecruit).

THEY ASK	HOW TO ANSWER
Walk me through an ITP you ran.	One unit: scope, number of points, who signed, what you caught. Two minutes, with numbers.
Hold point versus witness point?	Hold: work stops until you release it. Witness: you are notified and may attend; work proceeds if you do not. One example of each.
Tell me about an NCR the contractor pushed back on.	The defect, the clause, the conversation, the corrective action, the retest. End with what changed afterward.
What does "right first time" mean to you?	Owner vocabulary at Microsoft and Google. Mock-ups, first-article inspection, benchmarking the first install. Give a rework number you moved.
Have you worked with L1 to L5?	"Not under those names. I have done pre-commissioning, loop checks, startups and performance tests, which map to L2 through L5." Then line them up.
Describe a chilled-water system.	Chillers make cold water, pumps move it, CRAH coils pick up heat in the hall, condenser water or air-cooled units reject it outside. If you ran cooling water on a plant, say so.
What goes in a turnover package?	As-builts, test reports, vendor O&M data, certifications, punch closure, the closed issues log. Say which one the owner's rep fought you on last time.
Describe a conflict with a stakeholder.	The owner wanted to skip a test to make a date. What you said, what you offered instead, what happened.

Five questions to ask them

- Which commissioning levels is the site in right now, and on which systems?
- Who is the CxA, and how does the GC quality team work with them?
- Is the quality program on Procore, ACC Build or CxAlloy?
- What are the rotation and per diem, and how is per diem handled past twelve months?
- What does the next phase of this campus look like, and when does hiring for it start?

The one sentence to have ready: "I have spent ten years making sure industrial piping, welding and equipment were built to code and documented so an owner could take them over with confidence. The equipment on a data center is different and I am already studying it. The discipline is the same."

SECTION 10

Where the jobs are

Everywhere there is cheap land and spare power, which in 2026 means most of the country. By JLL's count, 64% of the capacity under construction at the end of 2025 was in "frontier markets," places that had no data centers five years ago (JLL via Bisnow). They are small towns with big projects, exactly like an LNG or petrochemical build: tight housing, per diem, crews from everywhere.

MARKET	WHY IT MATTERS NOW
Atlanta	About 2,900 MW under construction, now the largest in the country (CBRE)
Northern Virginia	The original hub, 0.2% vacancy, still expanding toward Culpeper and Richmond
Texas	Dallas–Fort Worth, plus West Texas campuses at Abilene, Amarillo, El Paso and Shackelford County
Louisiana	Meta's Richland Parish campus growing to 5 GW through 2036, AWS in Shreveport and Bossier, Hut 8 near Baton Rouge
Ohio	Columbus area, 896 MW under construction at the end of 2025 (JLL)
Arizona	Phoenix, one of the biggest pipelines in the country
The next wave	Oregon, Nevada, Mississippi, North Dakota, Pennsylvania, Tennessee, Wisconsin (Indeed Hiring Lab)

How to search any market

1. Search the title from section 4 plus "data center" plus the state on Indeed, LinkedIn and ZipRecruiter.
2. Go straight to the GC and owner's rep career pages: DPR, Turner, Mortenson, Holder, HITT, Clayco, Decima, KALCON. They post before the aggregators.
3. Register with three staffing firms that fill these roles, such as Insight Global, Actalent and Kelly, and tell them your travel range.
4. For the biggest owner sites, find out which general contractors, MEP subcontractors and staffing firms are on the job. Local news and the contractors' own project pages usually name them. Then apply to those companies directly.
5. Trades: if you are in a union, call your local and ask what data center jobs are open. The pipefitters' union (UA) and the electricians' union (IBEW) both post them with pay and per diem. If you are not union, apply directly to the electrical and mechanical contractors working on the site. They do most of the hiring for craft.

The full list of employers, owner's reps, commissioning firms and staffing agencies, each with a careers link, is at **missionqual.com/resources/employers**. Jobs This Week, a short list of real openings with a note on why each fits an oil and gas background, is posted in the community first (section 12).

SECTION 11

The 30-day plan

Thirty days is enough to go from "thinking about it" to interviews if you work in this order.

Week 1: paperwork

- [ ] Rewrite five résumé bullets with the table in section 8. Use a real result or number where you can verify it.
- [ ] Write the four-line summary.
- [ ] Build the one-page project list.
- [ ] Scan every cert and card into one folder on your phone. Badging offices ask for them.
- [ ] Start OSHA 30 if you do not have it.
- [ ] Change your LinkedIn headline and turn on "Open to work" for the titles in section 4.

Week 2: the words

- [ ] Explain L1 to L5 out loud in your own words, using the ladder in section 6.
- [ ] Do the free Procore field and quality certificates. Add them to your résumé.
- [ ] Learn what each box in the power and cooling diagram in section 2 does.
- [ ] Follow ten employers from section 10 and set job alerts for the section 4 titles.
- [ ] Save five live postings and highlight every word you can honestly claim.

Week 3: people

- [ ] Apply to five postings that say "industrial" or "or equivalent experience." A short note, not a cover letter: who you are, three things that transfer, when you can start.

- [ ] Call two staffing firms. Give them your trade, certs, travel range and rate. Ask what they are filling this month.

- [ ] Message three people on LinkedIn who hold the title you want. Ask one question: what they wish they had known before their first data center job.

- [ ] Union members: ask the hall which data center calls are open.

Week 4: practice

- [ ] Rehearse the eight interview answers in section 9 out loud.

- [ ] Follow up on every application and recruiter call from week 3.

- [ ] Have one real conversation with someone on a data center site. If you do not know anyone yet, ask in the MISSIONQUAL community and someone on site will answer.

- [ ] Pick the one certification you will start after your first project.

If an offer comes, get the rate, per diem, hours, rotation, dates, travel and housing terms, and contract type in writing before you say yes. **If it does not,** that is normal. Just keep applying. Ask every recruiter who passes on you what would have changed their mind, and work on that.

SECTION 12

Don’t make this move alone

This guide shows you the way. The MissionQual community walks it with you. It is a private group of oil and gas professionals who have made the move to data center construction, or are making it now.

What you get when you join

- **Straight answers from people on site.** Which contractors are good to work for, what a site is really like, what people with your background are actually being paid, and whether a role is the right next step for you. Inspectors, CWIs, electricians and pipefitters working data center builds now answer the questions no search engine can.
- **Jobs This Week.** Real data center QA/QC, inspection, commissioning and trade openings, each with a short note on why an oil and gas background fits. Posted in the community before anywhere else.
- **Introductions.** When a member’s site or contractor is hiring, the community hears about it first, and you get the chance to be put in front of the right person.
- **First access to live sessions.** Workshops on commissioning levels, Q&As with recruiters and hiring managers who staff data center jobs, and “how I got hired” walk-throughs from members who just made the move, open to members before anyone else.

Founding members. The first 100 people to join are the Founding Circle. You help shape what the community becomes, and you keep founding-member access to everything we add later.

JOIN THE COMMUNITY

Bring one question to the MissionQual community.

Ask the people who have already made the move. missionqual.com

More on the website: the full data center glossary (missionqual.com/resources/glossary), the employer and staffing directory (missionqual.com/resources/employers), and the sources behind this guide (missionqual.com/resources/sources).

Figure sources: Project-duration chart — DCD, Epoch AI, WWNO and Meta (turnaround length typical). Commissioning-level diagram — Horizon IQ, Archdesk and CxPlanner. Pay chart — posted rates from Insight Global, Contract Safety Professionals, Actalent, UA and Rigzone (May–October 2026).